

***From Erasure to Recovery: Restoring Space, Identity, and  
Memory in Tehran***



Tehran, Iran. Azadi Monument. 1971.

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ARCH 458M

July 15<sup>th</sup>, 2025

Tehran was historically known for its greenery and abundance of pomegranate gardens, long before it transformed into a metropolis. In its early development, the city was known for its natural landscape, gardens, trees, and fertile land that supported the ecosystem. Pomegranates, in particular, were a defining feature of Tehran's identity, deeply rooted in Persian culture as symbols of life, beauty, and fertility (Chitsaz 2019, 49). Both the city's green spaces and many pomegranate gardens shaped the cultural and environmental identity of Tehran before the rapid urban redevelopment of buildings. The rapid urbanization of Tehran has erased much of Tehran's public green spaces—such as the city's historic pomegranate gardens that once sustained cultural memory and ecological resilience.

While the 2007 film *Tehran Has No Pomegranates* reflects the broader tension between modernization and heritage, this paper will examine how two contemporary landscape projects—the Tabiat Bridge and Ferdows Garden—respond to this transformation by restoring environmental memory. Reclaiming green space in Tehran reveals both the potential and significance of restoring cultures and identity in the city, where it is often sacrificed for development. A brief comparison with the Gardens of Babur will provide regional context, emphasizing how landscape restoration can contribute to healing cultural identity.



Figure 1: Bakhshi, Massoud. *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates*. 2007. Iranian Film.

In *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates* (2007), the pomegranate, a symbol of fertility and paradise in Persian tradition, is slowly disappearing from the urban environment. (see figure 1) Through this visual and symbolic absence, the film not only expresses sorrow for the environment but also the cultural disorientation that follows, suggesting that when landscapes disappear (Danilina 2021, 986), so do the memories, values, and identities that are rooted within (Atwood 2016, 73). Massoud Bakhshi offers a significant visual and narrative on the erasure of green space and the slow loss of cultural memory in the capital (Bakhshi 2007). Through collages of archival footage, shots of the city, and voice-over commentary, Bakhshi constructs a sarcastic yet evocative portrayal showing many aching images

of Tehran's transformation from a city of gardens to one of concrete and consumerism (Bakhshi 2007).

Bakhshi uses quick cuts between archival images and current shots of overcrowded highways and high-rises (Atwood 2016, 181), allowing viewers to feel the rupture in the city's memoryscape. (see figure 2) The mise-en-scène of urban congestion, industrial development, and neglected spaces contrasts with lingering black-and-white images of older Tehran, where gardens were integral to city life. As emphasized in *Why Space Matters*, space in Middle Eastern cinema is not a "neutral background" but a dynamic force that reflects social and historical change (Khatib 2006, 15–17). Khatib has a point which resonates with my analysis: space in Middle Eastern cinema often works as a narrative and symbolic force, shaping how characters relate to or act in their environment, even within political and cultural dynamics. Furthermore, most Arab and Iranian directors often portray space as "foreground"—tied to the political and emotional conflicts of a place (Khatib 2006, 16).



Figure 2: Tehran, Iran. The View of The City.

In Bakhshi's film, the absence of green space becomes a metaphor for cultural decay and urban disorientation. The residents turn away from both the past and place within the space of Tehran (Bakhshi 2007). This aligns with the argument from *Why Space Matters* that "space is not fixed" (Khatib 2006, 17) but instead is "produced by social relations" (Khatib 2006, 15) and becomes a site of conflict and power. This is where I see that cinema becomes a form of resistance—one that preserves traces of a vanishing element of the city while challenging the dominant narratives of progress and modernity. In this sense, *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates* becomes both an archive and a critique, reclaiming spatial memory even as the physical landscape weakens.

*Tehran Has No More Pomegranates* uses the city's vanishing green spaces as a metaphor for cultural loss and social fragmentation amid rapid modernization. The film critically portrays

how Tehran's urban transformation erases shared spaces that once fostered cultural memories (Bakhshi 2007). Through mise-en-scène, framing of losses, and fragmented landscapes, the film highlights feelings of disconnection rooted in environmental and social change.

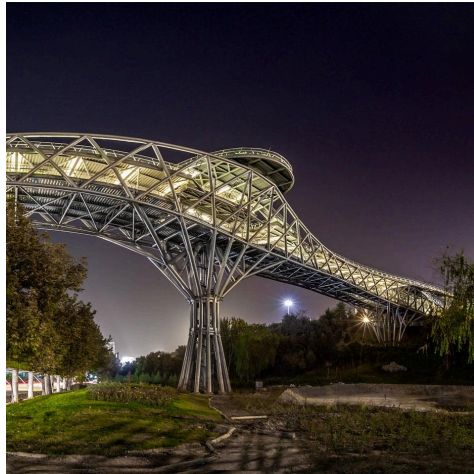


Figure 3: Tehran, Iran. Tabiat Bridge. 2010.  
Shot from the bottom.

Although the film mentions how modernism destroyed much of the greenery and important buildings, the Tabiat Bridge (2014), designed by architect Leila Araghian, stands as a powerful example of how contemporary landscape interventions (Diba Tensile 2014) can restore environmental memory in Tehran. (see figure 3) The Tabiat Bridge is linked by two major parks—Taleghani and Abo-Atash. The bridge functions not merely as infrastructure, but as a pedestrian-friendly space that encourages slowness, reflection, and social interaction (Ahmadi 2019, 14). As shown in the short documentary

*Tabiat Pedestrian Bridge: Tehran, Iran* (Ikonotv 2022),

the bridge is portrayed through sweeping drone shots, panoramic framing, and low-angle perspectives that emphasize its organic form and layered structure (Ikonotv 2022). These visual choices highlight the bridge's integration with the surrounding natural landscape (Diba Tensile 2014; Wescoat Jr 2016, 38), as well as its symbolic physical and social role in reconnecting



Figure 4: Tehran, Iran. Tabiat Bridge. 2010.  
Over headshot.

fragmented urban environments (Gharipour 2016, 1–3; Wescoat Jr 2016, 36).

The film's mise-en-scène often captures pedestrians walking, pausing, or interacting along the curved pathways and shaded platforms—framing them against both the skyline and tree canopies

(Ahmadi 2019, 11–12). (see figure 4) This human presence is at the center of the structure's narrative

and reflects the capacity to foster shared public life: reconnecting not only physical green spaces



but also fostering public life in a city (Diba Tensile 2014; Wescoat Jr 2016, 38) that is increasingly defined by car-dominated planning. Yet questions remain: Does this elegant infrastructure truly restore the cultural memory of lost gardens? While it gestures toward ecological awareness and healing, I believe that its reliance on controlled and carefully staged environments might limit deeper historical engagement with the landscape traditions it claims to revive. Tehran's urban development has pointed to the loss of green spaces (Danilina 2021, 976), but the Tabiat Bridge, in both design and representation, offers a counternarrative. Its flowing, non-linear architecture resists the rigid (Diba Tensile 2014) and utilitarian character of much modern infrastructure. It's a place for “staying” instead of “passing,” an idea of ecological connection with humans and nature (Ahmadi 2019, 14). I find this idea compelling, as the bridge's design encourages lingering and interaction rather than movement alone, allowing a deeper ecological connection between people and their environment (Gharipour 2016, 6–8).

As discussed in the *Contemporary Landscape Projects* reading, such projects are spatial and symbolic responses to historical forces (Gharipour 2016, 13–15). This insight is captivating, as it highlights how landscapes are used not to shape the space, but to reclaim memory and respond to historical trauma. Through the cinematic lens, the bridge becomes more than an object—it is a stage for collective memory, a platform for visibility, and a reclamation of space in an often chaotic urban environment. ( see figure 5) Within the context of the critique presented in *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates*, which highlights the disintegration of historical identity, the Tabiat Bridge can be seen as both a hopeful intervention and a response. It offers a new kind of visibility and space for connection. Still, its ability to sustain environmental memory or address ecological sustainability (Gharipour 2016, 8–11) in a meaningful way remains open to interpretation.



Figure 5: Tehran, Iran. Tabiat Bridge. 2010. High-Level shot of The Whole Bridge.

Another significant structure is the Ferdows Garden, one of Tehran's few surviving Qajar-era gardens—a garden that provides a direct link to the city's pre-modern landscape

traditions (Alder 2016, 120–121; Tasnim News Agency 2018), unlike the more recent and symbolic Tabiat Bridge. Ferdows Garden represents a preserved cultural site that has endured through regimes of modernization (Khalilnezhad 2024, 122). Samira Makhmalbaf's 2003 film *5 O'Clock in the Afternoon* is focused on using the peaceful park as a symbolic backdrop for Darya's emotional journey (Makhmalbaf 2003). (see figure 6) The garden reflects her inner struggle with grief, loneliness, and the search for meaning after a personal crisis. The title time "5 PM" marks a turning point of reflection in her life within the park (Alder 2016, 125; Gharipour 2016, 3). Ferdows Garden functions not only as a real location but also as a framed cinematic space (Atwood 2016, 198) that highlights the significance of green public areas in post-war Kabul and, more broadly, in Persian urban life (Alder 2016, 125; Tasnim News Agency 2018). Through wide-angle establishing shots and



Figure 6: Makhmalbaf, Samira. *5 O'Clock in the Afternoon*. 2003. Iranian Film.



Figure 7: Makhmalbaf, Samira. *5 O'Clock in the Afternoon*. 2003. Darya in the Ferdows Garden meditating alongside Nature.

deep-focus cinematography, the film captures the spatial openness (Koliji 2016, 152) and symmetry of the garden's layout, emphasizing its contrast to the chaotic, rubble-strewn cityscape shown in earlier scenes (Makhmalbaf 2003). The mise-en-scène of the film, dominated by lush trees, symmetrical paths (Frampton 2001, 9–16), and historical architecture, evokes a sense of stability, order, and cultural continuity (Alder 2016, 125; Koliji 2016, 152).

In those scenes, the garden becomes a visual and emotional refuge, reinforcing the theme of

restoration and healing (Makhmalbaf 2003). (see figure 7) Additionally, the framing choices often place characters within the garden's geometrical lines or behind iron gates and windows, subtly referencing themes of limitation, aspiration, and access to public life (Khalilnezhad 2024, 132–133).

Critically, while the film notes that it presents a pace that can feel slow, this thoughtful rhythm mirrors the quiet resistance embodied in spaces like Ferdows Garden—places that endure the pressure of modernization and sociopolitical rupture (Frampton 2001, 10). Today, the garden's role as the site of the Iranian Cinema Museum (Alder 2016, 126; Tasnim News Agency 2018) adds another layer of cultural memory, transforming it into a living archive (Koliji 2016, 155–157). (see figure 8) As noted in the *Contemporary Landscape Projects* reading, preserved green spaces like gardens serve to promote environmental benefits, create a more organic relationship, and improve quality of life (Koliji 2016, 155–157; Gharipour 2016, 2–3).

Gharipour's observation is true, and I agree, because in a city like Tehran, the preservation of spaces like Ferdows Garden provides opportunities for ecological awareness and improved quality of life in dense urban development. By presenting the garden not only as a setting but as



Figure 8: Tehran, Iran. Ferdow Garden. 2002.  
Front Elevation with the Main Garden.

a symbol, the film affirms the potential of landscape restoration to support both collective memory and cultural identity (Khatib 2006, 17). While the film shows the garden's accessibility and its role in everyday urban life, it also prompts us to ask: How deeply do such spaces engage with the layered cultural memory of lost Persian gardens? Can preservation alone heal the ruptures caused by war,

development, and urban neglect? I believe that the garden's current function as the Iranian Cinema

Museum further complicates its role—blending nostalgia with an arranged national identity.

However, from an environmental standpoint, Ferdows Garden preserves biodiversity and traditional garden design, but its scale and limited reach raise questions about broader urban sustainability (Khalilnezhad 2024, 132). Compared to *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates*, which frames Tehran's transformation as a loss of soul, Ferdows Garden serves as a quiet but incomplete rebuttal. It offers emotional and cultural healing in fragments (Gharipour 2016, 15),



but whether it can stand against the overwhelming forces of erasure and reinvention remains an open conversation.

However, a similar case of restoration is found in the Gardens of Babur in Kabul, offering a meaningful counterpoint to the landscape interventions in Afghanistan and highlighting the tension between cultural revival through historical reclamation and modernization through symbolic renovation. Once a majestic Mughal garden, the Gardens of Babur suffered extensive damage during decades of war and neglect (Dunham 2013, 67). Its restoration, led by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture in the early 2000s, aimed to revive the site's physical beauty and reestablish continuity with Afghanistan's royal and Islamic heritage (Dunham 2013, 71). (see figure 9) This was a purposeful act of cultural recovery—restoring not just a place, but a



Figure 9: Kabul, Afghanistan. Gardens of Babur in Kabul. 2002. Front Elevation with the Garden.

narrative of historical identity, pride, and ecological tradition (Amiri 2014, 449). Unlike Tehran's Tabiat Bridge, which is a contemporary invention designed to reconnect fragmented urban space, the Gardens of Babur involve reclaiming a historic landscape, reinforcing an ancestral connection to the land.

This contrast clarifies the purposes of these projects, as the Gardens of Babur embody cultural revival after conflict (The Aga Khan Trust for Culture 2004, 6; Ray 2017), while Ferdows Garden in Tehran represents the preservation of heritage amid urban growth and spatial compression (Alder 2016, 126–127). Meanwhile, the Tabiat Bridge does not restore a specific site but responds to a similar crisis by creating new green space that fosters social gathering and reconnection. All three projects engage with the theme of healing, responding to urban disruption with landscapes that promote emotional recovery, ecological awareness, and shared identity (Amiri 2014, 456–457).

In addition, Ferdows Garden encourages the ongoing maintenance of historical gardens within a contemporary, functioning urban context—offering daily accessibility and cultural



grounding of paradise (Frampton 2001, 15) in an evolving metropolis. While the Gardens of Babur explicitly restore a royal burial site tied to Afghan identity and traditions (The Aga Khan Trust for Culture 2004, 11; Ray 2017), Tehran's projects invoke these values symbolically. Ferdows Garden blends Iranian royal leisure culture with modern urban life, preserving ties to a larger garden legacy. The Tabiat Bridge, though modern in form, echoes traditional ideas of social gathering, contemplation, and harmony with nature. I can see how these projects reflect broader efforts to rebuild cultural identity in the face of modernization. They reclaim green space not just as territory, but as a stage for memory, belonging, and meaning in rapidly transforming cities.

In conclusion, *Tehran Has No More Pomegranates* critiques the disconnect and rapid modernization (Atwood 2016, 184) effects of unchecked urban growth. Both landscape architecture and film reveal how green space can act as a medium for reclaiming cultural meaning in the modern Middle East. As this paper has shown, the Tabiat Bridge and Ferdows Garden personally respond to Tehran's transformation by restoring not only physical environments (Marefat 2008, 57) but also the cultural and emotional memory tied to nature, gathering, and identity (Khatib 2006, 17). These projects reflect different strategies—symbolic reinvention in the case of the bridge, and historical preservation in the case of the garden—while contributing to reestablishing continuity in an urban landscape.

The comparison with the Gardens of Babur further highlights the regional significance of green space as a tool for cultural recovery (Ray 2017), whether through the restoration of historic sites or the reinterpretation of traditional values in contemporary form (Gharipour 2016, 11). Film and architecture alike participate in this dialogue: they frame space, evoke memory, and offer the possibility of healing. While urban design projects like the Tabiat Bridge and Ferdows Garden cannot fully reverse the cultural erosion caused by modernization, they suggest that green space remains a powerful establishment for collective identity (Gharipour 2016, 3, 6). Ultimately, projects with a connection to greenery in modern Middle Eastern cities can truly reclaim their sense of cultural meaning through landscape. Although it won't reverse the damage, preserving the past by shaping public spaces will help nurture reflection, connection, and belonging (Marefat 2008, 52).

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